

Beyond this Module - Documentation & Reporting

Proper documentation and reporting are critical soft skills for any IT or infosec role. It can be tedious and time-consuming, but if we organize ourselves properly and practice "documenting as you go," it can be a much smoother process. There are many opportunities to refine your notetaking format, find the best tool for your purposes, and figure out the best directory format for you. The tips in this module are just those, a collection of things that have worked well for us. It's essential to develop your own style that fits best in your workflow and does not overcomplicate things. Whether you are already working in infosec or are still trying to break into the industry, it's always good to find opportunities to refine this critical soft skill.

Practicing

There are many ways you can practice documentation and reporting.

- Experiment with several different notetaking tools while playing active and retired HTB boxes, End Games, Pro Labs, Academy modules, and other training content. Record your enumeration, exploitation, post-exploitation, findings, scans, etc., in as much detail as possible.
- Practice approaching individual boxes and labs as if they were a real-world engagement and use reporting templates to practice writing professional reports. You can use the report template provided with this module, find sample pentest reports on GitHub, or use the report templates included in tools such as [WriteHat](#), [Pwndoc](#), or something similar.
- Read through reports in the [public pentesting reports repo](#) to expose yourself to various reporting styles.
- If you don't have time to create a full-blown report for each box you play, at the very least, choose 1-2 vulnerabilities in the box or lab and write them up as professional findings in your notes. Do this enough times, and you'll have the makings of a solid findings database.
- Start a personal blog and make walkthroughs or retired HTB boxes and challenges, tier0 modules, and CTFs that you participate in. Write about vulnerabilities and techniques that interest you, even if other blog posts already exist on the topic. Creating well-thought-out posts on your favorite technologies, video games, or personal interests is another great way to practice your writing skills. Your blog may be something potential employers come across or a great asset to add when applying for a job.
- Share your writings with friends, peers, and colleagues and ask them for feedback and how you can improve.
- Find other people's blogs whose writing style you enjoy and read their posts regularly to get different viewpoints on how people approach problems and get ideas on different ways to describe findings, concepts, and ideas. Reading can help us grow as writers.
- It can be very beneficial to use GitHub Pages and a Git workflow to document personal projects, build familiarity with Git, and practice thorough documentation.

Becoming a good writer can help you in many aspects of your career. Professional written communication is not a skill you can learn overnight and something you can only improve with considerable practice. Professional writing skills can elevate you to new heights and make you more effective in almost every role you assume in your career, even if it's not penetration testing or even as a consultant; maybe you'll even be writing HTB Academy modules one day!

Next Steps

After this module, I recommend completing the [Penetration Testing Process](#) module (if you have not already) to better understand the bigger picture and how every module in the [Penetration Tester](#) path fits together. Finally, complete the [Attacking Enterprise Networks](#) module. This can be considered the capstone module for the [Penetration Tester](#) path and puts together skills taught in every module into a simulated External Penetration Test resulting in internal compromise. Approach the network in this module as a real-world penetration test and practice your documentation and reporting skills.

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